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A STRATEGY IN DISARRAY

The policy of recovering, holding and developing territorial areas against Maoists is not working

The brave response of SRP Kalluri, DIG, anti-Naxal operations, Dantewada, was revealing. "We had cleared that area," he said, referring to the stretch where a Central Reserve Police Force (CRPF) company had been ambushed to devastating effect. "Now we will sanitise it again." Union Home Secretary G.K. Pillai disclosed that 5,000 square km had been 'recovered' from the Maoists in Rajnandgaon and Kanker districts over the past four months, and that "civil administration had been restored" there. These two statements encapsulate everything that is wrong with the current anti-Maoist operational 'strategy'.

Both officials are evidently fighting a very different war. The Maoists seek disruptive dominance, not territorial or administrative control. The Indian state, on the other hand, appears to be fighting to 'recover' territories that are not held by the Maoists in any meaningful sense. The moment the situation stabilises and force presence is diluted, the Maoists will 'restore' their disruptive dominance with a few attacks. In the interim, while the security forces' operational capacities are concentrated in these districts, the Maoists will simply walk away without a fight, and strike elsewhere, as in Dantewada. As the DIG Dantewada notes, areas 'cleared' by him are quickly 'infected' once again, and have to be 'sanitised'.

The startling simplicity of the current anti-Naxal 'strategy' is remarkable. Chhattisgarh DGP Vishwa Ranjan says it aims to pack a small area with adequate force, forcing the Naxals to flee the area. Once they retreat, the area will be developed. When that area is developed, the forces will move to another area and develop it. There is however, no effective strategy or deployment to 'contain' or neutralise the Maoists... hence

Dantewada. And when you get around to 'squeezing' Dantewada, they will walk back into Rajnandgaon or some other region, or beyond.

A simple lesson from the highly successful 'Andhra Pradesh model' (much more than just Greyhounds) is that every inch of the state has been simultaneously dominated to neutralise the shifting guerrilla strategy of the Maoists. It is significant, here, that the Centre's 'strategy' to 'clear, hold and develop', is already being questioned at the highest levels. Crucially, senior CRPF officials have already declared that 'holding' territory is no longer a sustainable operational objective, and that they would increasingly focus on surgical intelligence-based operations targeting the Maoist leadership.

Why has this 'strategy' collapsed? Simply because it was not a strategy at all, but a set of arbitrary, disconnected and often event, media, or politics-driven decisions, disconnected with the conditions on the ground.

The operational errors of the Dantewada attack are being forced by strategic infirmities. Given the paucity of forces and their thin dispersal across vast areas, no rational deployment is possible, vulnerabilities are endemic, and 'mistakes' are inevitable.

What is a 'strategy'? If there is a fundamental dis-

connect between objectives, tactics, resources and ground conditions, there is no strategy. This is the core of the current failure: objectives are unclear, there is no unanimity on tactics, and the saturation of force, resources and capacities that is necessary for anything measuring up to a 'clear, hold and develop' capability is absent. A long succession of similar Maoist attacks—albeit with smaller total fatalities—preceded the latest tragedy at Dantewada. We have not learned our lessons. There will be many more to come. ■



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